> The region that caused us special anxiety was the region of Tawang in the extreme north-west corner of Kameng Frontier Division and across the 14,000 foot Se La Pass [Sela]. Although Tawang was undoubtedly south of the McMahon Line and therefore within the territory of India, the Tibetans had, for generations, felt a strong sentimental attachment to the area, partly as the birth-place of the sixth Dalai Lama. The office-bearers of the great Buddhist monastery at Tawang were sometimes selected from among the Tibetan lamas of the famous Drepung monastery near Lhasa and the culture of the region had affinities with Tibet as much as with India.[110]

Rustomji and his border officials decided it was time to make clear to which country Tawang belonged—something which had become especially important since the Chinese occupation of Tibet in 1950. In 1938, the British had sent a military expedition led by Captain Gordon Lightfoot to plant the flag at Tawang, though little had happened since then. But the Indians remembered Captain Nevill's warning from as early as 1928 that should the Chinese gain control over Tibet, which they now had, Tawang would provide a 'secret and easy entrance into India'.[111]

The local population in Tawang are known as Monpas and speak a language related to Tibetan, but they do not consider themselves ethnic Tibetans. In a confidential report, compiled by the secretariat of the Governor of Assam after Lightfoot's expedition, it was stated that the Monpas 'live in a state of virtual slavery… [and] that brutal punishments are inflicted on the British Monpas by irregular Tibetan courts…His Excellency is satisfied that inhabitants of the British area are from time to time murdered…under the orders of officials of the Tibetan Government.'[112] Apart from meting out harsh sentences against the local population, the Tibetan officials in the area did little more than collect money from the locals and send it to the Tsona (Cona) monastery in Tibet. Thus, it came hardly as a surprise to Lightfoot that the Monpas supported him against their Tibetan overlords when he entered the area.

The report from the Assam Secretariat suggested that the Tibetan Government should withdraw their officials from Tawang, and that the British should establish a more permanent presence in the district. That, however, did not happen because of the outbreak of World War II in 1939. It was not until February 1951, three and a half years after India's independence, that a detachment of the paramilitary Assam Rifles marched over Sela Pass and into the salient Tawang. It was commanded by Major Ralengnao 'Bob' Khathing, a Tangkhul Naga from Manipur, and, according to Rustomji, 'Bob's entry into Tawang was, for them [the Monpas], a true